

The Information Daily Briefing — 2026-08-05

Technology, business and investment intelligence from the last 24 hours

Wednesday, 5 August 2026 (GMT+8)

The Information Daily Briefing

Coverage window: last 24 hours to the morning of 5 August 2026 (GMT+8) **Source:** *The Information* (Gmail newsletters + logged-in web reading) **Prepared:** 5 August 2026, ~07:20 GMT+8

Top Stories — What / Why / When / Which / How

1. Airtable sold to Bending Spoons for \$1.285B — a brutal markdown from its \$11B peak

- **What:** Once-hot productivity app Airtable is being acquired by Italian conglomerate Bending Spoons for **\$1.285 billion in cash**, a fraction of the \$11 billion valuation it carried at its 2021 peak. Just days before the sale, Airtable spun its six-month-old AI-agent platform **HyperAgent** into a standalone company, HyperAgent Inc., which existing investors will hold a stake in and which CEO Howie Liu plans to run full-time.
- **Why:** At under **3x annualized revenue**, the price resets valuation expectations for the entire crop of overpriced private enterprise-software startups (Airtable was No. 2 on The Information's takeover list). It is a template for how the 2021 vintage exits: a deep-discount sale plus a "fresh start" AI spin-out.
- **When:** Announced Tuesday, 4 August 2026.
- **Which:** Airtable, Bending Spoons, HyperAgent Inc.; late-stage backers XN, Thrive Capital, Greenoaks; early winners CRV and Caffeinated Capital.
- **How:** Airtable's ~\$900M cash balance is distributed to preferred holders first, so most investors roughly recoup capital; Bain Capital Ventures' Aaref Hilaly estimates ~\$850M is left for common holders (~\$127M for ~900 employees after founders). Common stock bought in 2021 secondaries lost money.
- **Link:** <https://www.theinformation.com/newsletters/dealmaker/inside-airtable-bending-spoons-sale>

2. Palantir's "rocket-ship" quarter — revenue up 93%, stock rips

- **What:** Palantir posted **~93% revenue growth** for the June quarter (well above guidance), lifting quarterly revenue to **\$1.9 billion** from \$533M three years ago. Shares jumped ~11% after hours and closed up nearly **30% on Tuesday** on record U.S.-enterprise contract value.
- **Why:** Palantir is monetizing AI *without building its own foundation models* — it generated **\$2.1B of operating cash in H1 2026 on just \$22M of capex**, the software-layer economics every rival covets. The Information dubs it "the Nvidia of AI software."

- **When:** Earnings Monday 3 August; analysis published 3 August 2026 (5:01pm PDT).
- **Which:** Palantir (PLTR); ecosystem names it sits on top of — Snowflake, Salesforce, SAP; rhetorical foils Anthropic and OpenAI.
- **How:** CEO Alex Karp pairs end-to-end data software and AI agents with a marketing message that enterprises shouldn't "hand the creators of the language models the keys to their institutions" — positioning Palantir as the safe intermediary.
- **Link:** <https://www.theinformation.com/newsletters/the-briefing/palantirs-rocket-ship-growth>

3. Big customers are building their own coding agents to cap Anthropic/OpenAI bills

- **What:** Coinbase, Shopify and Ramp have built **in-house AI coding agents** as cheaper alternatives to Anthropic's Claude Code and OpenAI's tools. Coinbase's agent, **Forge**, launched to all engineers in April and routes across Anthropic, OpenAI, Google and open-source models.
- **Why:** It shows enterprises actively engineering *down* their AI spend even as usage rises — Coinbase says spend fell while token usage grew; Brian Armstrong claims the company nearly halved AI costs, partly via Chinese open-source models (GLM 5.2, Kimi K2.7). A structural pressure on model vendors' per-seat pricing power.
- **When:** Reported 4 August 2026.
- **Which:** Coinbase, Shopify (agent "River"), Ramp, Globant, Walmart (in-house "Code Puppy," later capped); vendors Anthropic, OpenAI, Cursor.
- **How:** Internal model routers pick the cheapest capable model per task; agents live inside Slack, GitHub, Datadog and Sentry. Notably, Claude Code remains the *most-used* tool among Coinbase's 2,500 AI-using engineers — complement, not full replacement.
- **Link:** <https://www.theinformation.com/newsletters/applied-ai/firms-like-coinbase-building-coding-agents-complement-anthropics-claude-code>

4. Voice-AI startup Listen Labs in talks for \$125M at a ~\$1.5B valuation

- **What:** San Francisco's **Listen Labs**, which automates customer interviews with voice AI, is raising **\$125 million at ~\$1.5 billion**, with Anthropic backer **Menlo Ventures** in talks to lead.
- **Why:** The round would **triple** the valuation in seven months, underscoring how hot applied voice-AI is — even as practitioners warn that voice AI at scale is still often more expensive than offshore call centers.
- **When:** Reported 4 August 2026.
- **Which:** Listen Labs; investors Menlo Ventures, Ribbit, Sequoia, Conviction; customers Microsoft, Sweetgreen, Perplexity; rivals Conveo, Strella.
- **How:** The AI runs semi-scripted interviews and generates follow-up questions on the fly. Listen Labs reports ~\$30M ARR now and projects \$110M+ by year-end with <100 employees — a revenue-multiple bet on continued voice-model improvement.
- **Link:** <https://www.theinformation.com/newsletters/ai-agenda/customer-feedback-startup-talks-125-million-financing-led-anthropic-investor>

5. The case for a SpaceX-Tesla merger

- **What:** An analysis argues a **SpaceX acquisition of Tesla** would benefit both shareholder bases by consolidating Musk's focus and formalizing the deals the two already do together (shared engineers, Grok in Tesla vehicles, the planned "Terafab" chip-fab JV).
- **Why:** Their valuations have converged — SpaceX ~\$1.5T (~190x forward P/E) vs Tesla ~\$1.3T (~167x) — which makes a stock combination mechanically easier than when SpaceX was worth 2x Tesla right after its IPO.

- **When:** Published 4 August 2026; SpaceX's first post-IPO earnings were due the same day.
- **Which:** SpaceX (Starlink, launch, xAI/X), Tesla (autos 86% of revenue, energy, robotaxi, humanoid robots); comps Waymo, Amazon/Google/Microsoft (cloud).
- **How:** SpaceX would likely be acquirer (Musk holds supervoting shares there). Risks: combined **~\$34B net debt**, sustained cash burn (Tesla FCF turned negative in Q2; ≥\$25B capex planned in 2026), and a possible forced China divestiture that would "gut" Tesla's revenue engine.
- **Link:** <https://www.theinformation.com/articles/spacex-tesla-merger-benefit-shareholders-companies>

6. Policy, chips and the tape — the rest of the 24 hours

- **What:** The **Trump administration is drafting an FCC rule to ban Chinese-made data-center components** (targeted to take effect this year, citing malware/data-theft risk). Separately, major PC makers began using memory chips from China's **CXMT**; **Alibaba** released its flagship **Qwen3.8-Max** via API below Moonshot's Kimi K3 pricing (open weights next week); **Microsoft** finally closed positive for 2026 (+25% since its June-quarter print) and **Amazon** topped a **\$3 trillion** market cap for the first time; **Snap** revenue rose 19% (stock +9-10% after hours) but U.S./Europe user growth stayed flat.
- **Why:** The through-line is a **US-China tech-decoupling squeeze on data-center supply chains** running alongside a **mega-cap AI melt-up** — capital keeps concentrating in the infrastructure and platform winners.
- **When:** 3-4 August 2026.
- **Which:** FCC/White House, CXMT, Alibaba (BABA), Moonshot, Microsoft (MSFT), Amazon (AMZN), Snap (SNAP).
- **How:** Import restrictions + domestic-China chip substitution reshape hardware sourcing; hyperscaler earnings momentum drives index-level gains; Snap's growth is subscription-led, not ad- or user-led.
- **Links:** <https://www.theinformation.com/newsletters/ai-agenda/customer-feedback-startup-talks-125-million-financing-led-anthropic-investor> • <https://www.theinformation.com/newsletters/briefing/palantirs-rocket-ship-growth>

Overall Summary — Trend, Development & Sentiment

Market trend. Two forces dominate the tape. First, a **mega-cap AI melt-up**: Palantir's ~93% growth, Microsoft turning green for the year, and Amazon crossing \$3T show capital concentrating in the platform and infrastructure winners. Second, a **private-market reckoning**: Airtable's sale at ~11% of its peak valuation, and a wave of AI financings (Listen Labs at ~\$1.5B; Base Power's \$1B Series D; Horizon3 at \$2B+), show money flooding *into* AI-native names while 2021-vintage SaaS is marked down and consolidated.

Key development. A clear theme emerged of **enterprises pushing back on AI-vendor economics** — Coinbase, Shopify and Ramp building in-house, multi-model coding agents to cap Anthropic/OpenAI spend — while Palantir weaponizes "don't trust the model labs with your data" as a sales pitch. The application and orchestration layer, not the model layer, is where near-term profit is visibly accruing.

Sentiment. Risk-on at the top, sober underneath. Public AI leaders are being rewarded aggressively; private valuations are bifurcating between AI-native winners and everything else. Overlaying it all is escalating **US-China tech friction** (proposed FCC ban on Chinese data-center gear; CXMT substitution; cheaper Chinese open models) that is both a supply-chain risk and a cost lever for buyers.

Important Questions & Risks Being Asked

- **Is model-vendor pricing power peaking?** If large customers can halve AI spend with internal routers and open-source (incl. Chinese) models, how durable are Anthropic/OpenAI per-seat economics?
 - **Is Palantir's multiple justified by durable moat, or by narrative?** Karp's anti-lab messaging is "all-too-convenient"; growth is real but the stock discounts years of continued acceleration.
 - **Has private SaaS repricing further to run?** Airtable at <3x revenue may reset the comp set for dozens of takeover targets — good for acquirers (Bending Spoons), painful for late-stage holders.
 - **Can capital-intensive Musk ambitions be financed?** A SpaceX-Tesla tie-up carries ~\$34B net debt and heavy capex; a China divestiture could gut Tesla's profit engine.
 - **Voice-AI unit economics:** Listen Labs' ~50x forward-revenue valuation assumes rapid margin/quality gains, yet practitioners say voice AI at scale still loses to offshore call centers.
 - **Regulatory/geopolitical:** How disruptive is an FCC ban on Chinese data-center components to hyperscaler build-outs, and does it accelerate a bifurcated global AI hardware stack?
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Potential Investment Implications

Companies named directly in today's articles. This is analysis for context only — not investment advice. Confirm all figures independently before acting.

- **Palantir (PLTR):** Fundamental momentum is exceptional (93% growth, ~\$2.1B H1 operating cash, minimal capex). The debate is valuation and narrative-dependence, not execution. Watch U.S.-commercial contract cadence and whether the "safe intermediary vs. model labs" positioning sustains pricing.
- **Microsoft (MSFT):** Re-rated on accelerating cloud + AI-chatbot revenue (+25% since its June print, first green close of 2026). A prime beneficiary of the platform melt-up; a proposed ban on Chinese data-center gear is a supply-chain cost/latency watch item.
- **Amazon (AMZN):** First-ever \$3T cap signals cloud/AI leadership is being repriced upward; same data-center supply-chain sensitivity applies.
- **Tesla (TSLA) / SpaceX:** Merger optionality could unlock synergies and cheaper combined debt issuance, but concentration, ~\$34B net debt, negative Tesla FCF and China-divestiture risk are material. Event risk around SpaceX's first post-IPO print.
- **Snap (SNAP):** Revenue +19% but growth is subscription-, not ad-/user-led, and U.S./Europe DAUs are flat-to-down. A trading bounce off lows rather than a confirmed turnaround; needs U.S. user re-acceleration.
- **Coinbase (COIN) / Shopify (SHOP):** Internal AI tooling (Forge, River) is a margin/efficiency positive and reduces dependence on external model vendors — a quiet operating-leverage story.
- **Alibaba (BABA):** Aggressive Qwen3.8-Max pricing and open-weights strategy strengthen its position in the cost-competitive/open-model tier; a beneficiary of enterprises seeking cheaper inference.
- **Nvidia (NVDA):** Referenced as the AI benchmark; unaffected directly today, but any hardware-decoupling rules and cheaper-inference trends bear on the demand narrative.
- **Private / M&A read-throughs:** **Bending Spoons** shows an acquirer thriving on discounted SaaS; **Airtable/HyperAgent**, **Listen Labs** (Menlo Ventures), **Base Power** (Ribbit, Valor, JPMorganChase SIG), **Horizon3**, **HappyRobot**, **Zenity** point to where late-stage capital is rotating — security, AI agents, and AI-native infrastructure — and away from generic productivity SaaS.

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